

2c. Content of Religion and ethics (H573/02)

In this component, learners have the opportunity to study key concepts related to religion and ethics.

As part of their study, learners will study four normative ethical theories, providing a range of approaches: deontological and teleological, religious and non-religious. These theories will then be applied to two issues of importance; euthanasia and business ethics. This allows learners to explore contemporary issues and deepen their understanding of the ethical theories.

Within *Ethical Language: Meta-ethics*, learners will explore how ethical language has changed over time and been interpreted by different individuals.

To develop learners' awareness of the importance of significant concepts within the study of ethics, they will be required to examine the significant ethical concept of conscience, through a comparison of the works of two key thinkers; Aquinas and Freud.

Finally, in *Developments in Ethical Thought*, learners will examine areas of sexual ethics, a highly relevant and interesting area of study. Learners will explore how attitudes to pre and extra marital sex and homosexuality have influenced and been influenced by developments in religious beliefs, and also how the four normative theories they previously studied can be applied to these areas.

Technical Terms

While the majority of non-English terms (which are not names of texts, philosophical schools, or particular religious approaches) given within the specification and assessment materials will be accompanied by a translation, there are some that are considered to be key technical terms that learners are expected to recognise and understand without a provided translation.

For this component, the following are considered technical terms and will not necessarily be accompanied by a translation:

- *agape*
- *conscientia*
- *ratio*
- *synderesis*
- *telos*.

1. Normative Ethical Theories: Religious Approaches

Two normative ethical theories taking a religious approach to moral decision-making

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Natural Law*	- Aquinas' natural law, including: <i>telos</i> - the four tiers of law - the precepts	- origins of the significant concept of <i>telos</i> in Aristotle and its religious development in the writing of Aquinas - what they are and how they are related: - Eternal Law: the principles by which God made and controls the universe and which are only fully known to God - Divine Law: the law of God revealed in the Bible, particularly in the Ten Commandments and the Sermon on the Mount - Natural Law: the moral law of God within human nature that is discoverable through the use of reason - Human Law: the laws of nations - what they are and how they are related - the key precept (do good, avoid evil) - five primary precepts (preservation of life, ordering of society, worship of God, education of children, reproduction) - secondary precepts
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues raised by Aquinas' theory of natural law, including: - whether or not natural law provides a helpful method of moral decision-making - whether or not a judgement about something being good, bad, right or wrong can be based on its success or failure in achieving its <i>telos</i> - whether or not the universe as a whole is designed with a <i>telos</i>, or human nature has an orientation towards the good - whether or not the doctrine of double effect can be used to justify an action, such as killing someone as an act of self-defence		
Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Aquinas listed above can be found in:</i> <i>Summa Theologica</i> I-II (93–95) Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Aristotle <i>Physics</i> II 3 - Catechism of the Catholic Church 1954–1960 - Stanford Encycloedia of Philosophy (2005 rev.2011) <i>Aquinas' Moral, Political and Legal Philosophy</i>, http://plato.stanford.edu/entries/aquinas-moral-political/		

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Situation Ethics*	- Fletcher's situation ethics, including: <i>agape</i> - the six propositions - the four working principles - conscience	- origins of <i>agape</i> in the New Testament and its religious development in the writing of Fletcher - what they are and how they give rise to the theory of situation ethics and its approach to moral decision-making: - Love is the only thing that is intrinsically good - Love is the ruling norm in ethical decision-making and replaces all laws - Love and justice are the same thing—justice is love that is distributed - Love wills the neighbour's good regardless of whether the neighbour is liked or not - Love is the goal or end of the act and that justifies any means to achieve that goal - Love decides on each situation as it arises without a set of laws to guide it - what they are and how they are intended to be applied: - pragmatism: it is based on experience rather than on theory - relativism: it is based on making the absolute laws of Christian ethics relative - positivism: it begins with belief in the reality and importance of love - personalism: persons, not laws or anything else, are at the centre of situation ethics - what conscience is and what it is not according to Fletcher, i.e. a verb not a noun; a term that describes attempts to make decisions creatively
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues raised by Fletcher's theory of situation ethics, including: - whether or not situation ethics provides a helpful method of moral decision-making - whether or not an ethical judgement about something being good, bad, right or wrong can be based on the extent to which, in any given situation, <i>agape</i> is best served - whether Fletcher's understanding of <i>agape</i> is really religious or whether it means nothing more than wanting the best for the person involved in a given situation - whether or not the rejection of absolute rules by situation ethics makes moral decision-making entirely individualistic and subjective	

Contextual references

For reference, the ideas of Fletcher listed above can be found in:

- *Situation Ethics The New Morality*

Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority

*Learners will be given credit for referring to any **appropriate** scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful*

- Lewis, C.S. (1960 rev.2016) *The Four Loves*, William Collins, Chapter 6
- Messer, N. (2006) *SCM Study guide: Christian Ethics*, London: SCM, Chapter 1

2. Normative Ethical Theories

Two normative ethical theories: one deontological, one teleological

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Kantian Ethics*	- Kantian ethics, including: - duty - the hypothetical imperative - the categorical imperative and its three formulations - the three postulates	- origins of the concept of duty (acting morally according to the good regardless of consequences) in deontological and absolutist approaches to ethics - what it is (a command to act to achieve a desired result) and why it is not the imperative of morality - what it is (a command to act that is good in itself regardless of consequences) and why it is the imperative of morality based on: - Formula of the law of nature (whereby a maxim can be established as a universal law) - Formula of the end in itself (whereby people are treated as ends in themselves and not means to an end) - Formula of the kingdom of ends (whereby a society of rationality is established in which people treat each other as ends and not means) - what they are and why in obeying a moral command they are being accepted: - Freedom - Immortality - God
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues raised by Kant's approach to ethics, including: - whether or not Kantian ethics provides a helpful method of moral decision-making - whether or not an ethical judgement about something being good, bad, right or wrong can be based on the extent to which duty is best served - whether or not Kantian ethics is too abstract to be applicable to practical moral decision-making - whether or not Kantian ethics is so reliant on reason that it unduly rejects the importance of other factors, such as sympathy, empathy and love in moral decision-making		

	Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Kant listed above can be found in:</i> • <i>Groundwork of the Metaphysic of Morals</i>, Chapter 2 Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> • Pojman, L. (2012) <i>Discovering Right and Wrong</i>, Stamford: Wadsworth, Chapter 8 • O'Neill, O. 'Kantian Approaches to Some Famine Problems' in ed. Shafer-Landau, R. (2013) <i>Ethical Theory: An Anthology</i>, Chichester: Wiley-Blackwell	
Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Utilitarianism*	• Utilitarianism, including: ◦ utility ◦ the hedonic calculus ◦ act utilitarianism ◦ rule utilitarianism	• the use of the significant concept of utility (seeking the greatest balance of good over evil, or pleasure over pain) in teleological and relativist approaches to ethics • what it is (calculating the benefit or harm of an act through its consequences) and its use as a measure of individual pleasure • what it is (calculating the consequences of each situation on its own merits) and its use in promoting the greatest amount of good over evil, or pleasure over pain • what it is (following accepted laws that lead to the greatest overall balance of good over evil, or pleasure over pain) and its use in promoting the common good
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues raised by utilitarianism, including: • whether or not utilitarianism provides a helpful method of moral decision-making • whether or not an ethical judgement about something being good, bad, right or wrong can be based on the extent to which, in any given situation, utility is best served • whether or not it is possible to measure good or pleasure and then reach a moral decision	
	Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> • Bentham, J. (1789) <i>An Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation</i> • Mill, J.S. (1863) <i>Utilitarianism</i> • Singer, P. (1993) <i>Practical Ethics</i>, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press • Pojman, L. (2012) <i>Discovering Right and Wrong</i>, Stamford: Wadsworth, Chapter 7	

3. Applied Ethics

The application of ethical theory, including religious ethical perspectives, to two issues of importance

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Euthanasia*	- Key ideas, including: - sanctity of life - quality of life - voluntary euthanasia - non-voluntary euthanasia	- the religious origins of this concept (that human life is made in God's image and is therefore sacred in value) - the secular origins of this significant concept (that human life has to possess certain attributes in order to have value) - what it is (that a person's life is ended at their request or with their consent) and its use in the case of incurable or terminal illness - what it is (that a person's life is ended without their consent but with the consent of someone representing their interests) and its use in the case of a patient who is in a persistent vegetative state
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues raised by euthanasia, including: - the application of natural law and situation ethics to euthanasia - whether or not the religious concept of sanctity of life has any meaning in twenty-first century medical ethics - whether or not a person should or can have complete autonomy over their own life and decisions made about it - whether or not there is a moral difference between medical intervention to end a patient's life and medical non-intervention to end a patient's life	
	Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Glover, J. (1977) <i>Causing Death and Saving Life</i>, London: Penguin Books, Chapters 14 and 15 - Sacred Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith (5th May 1980) <i>Declaration on Euthanasia</i> - Singer, P. (1995) <i>Rethinking Life and Death: The Collapse of our Traditional Ethics</i>, Oxford: OUP, Chapter 7	

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Business Ethics*	• Key ideas, including: ◦ corporate social responsibility ◦ whistle-blowing ◦ good ethics is good business ◦ globalisation	• what it is (that a business has responsibility towards the community and environment) and its application to stakeholders, such as employees, customers, the local community, the country as whole and governments • what it is (that an employee discloses wrongdoing to the employer or the public) and its application to the contract between employee and employer • what it is (that good business decisions are good ethical decisions) and its application to shareholders and profit-making • what it is (that around the world economies, industries, markets, cultures and policy-making is integrated) and its impact on stakeholders
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues raised by these areas of business ethics, including: • the application of Kantian ethics and utilitarianism to business ethics • whether or not the concept of corporate social responsibility is nothing more than 'hypocritical window-dressing' covering the greed of a business intent on making profits • whether or not human beings can flourish in the context of capitalism and consumerism • whether globalisation encourages or discourages the pursuit of good ethics as the foundation of good business		
Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> • Friedman, M. (September 13, 1970) 'The Social Responsibility of Business is to Increase its Profits', in <i>The New York Times Magazine</i>, The New York Times Company • Crane, A. & Matten, D. (2003) <i>Business Ethics</i>, Oxford: OUP • FTSE4Good [http://www.ftse.com/products/downloads/F4G-Index-Inclusion-Rules.pdf]		

4. Ethical Language: Meta-ethics

The study of meta-ethical theories and how ethical language in the modern era has changed over time

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Meta-ethical theories	- naturalism - intuitionism - emotivism	- what it is (the belief that values can be defined in terms of some natural property in the world) and its application to absolutism - what it is (the belief that basic moral truths are indefinable but self-evident) and its application to the term good - what it is (the belief that ethical terms evince approval or disapproval) and its application to relativism
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to meta-ethics, including: - whether or not what is meant by the word 'good' is the defining question in the study of ethics - whether or not ethical terms such as good, bad, right and wrong: - have an objective factual basis that makes them true or false in describing something - reflect only what is in the mind of the person using such terms - can be said to be meaningful or meaningless - whether or not, from a common sense approach, people just know within themselves what is good, bad, right and wrong		
Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Moore, G.E. (1903) <i>Principia Ethica</i>, Chapter II - Ayer, A.J. (1936) <i>Language, Truth and Logic</i>, London: Victor Gollancz, Chapter 6 - Mackie, J.L. (1977) <i>Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong</i>, London: Penguin Books, Part 1.3		

5. Significant Ideas

Significant ideas in religious and moral thought, through comparison of the works of two key scholars from the field of religion and ethics

Conscience	• Aquinas' theological approach • Freud's psychological approach	• details of this approach, including: ◦ <i>ratio</i> (reason placed in every person as a result of being created in the image of God) ◦ <i>synderesis</i> (inner principle directing a person towards good and away from evil) ◦ <i>conscientia</i> (a person's reason making moral judgements). ◦ vincible ignorance (lack of knowledge for which a person is responsible) ◦ invincible ignorance (lack of knowledge for which a person is not responsible) • details of this approach, including: ◦ psychosexual development (early childhood awareness of libido) ◦ id (instinctive impulses that seek satisfaction in pleasure) ◦ ego (mediates between the id and the demands of social interaction) ◦ super-ego (contradicts the id and working on internalised ideals from parents and society tries to make the ego behave morally)
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to ideas about conscience, including: • comparison between Aquinas and Freud: ◦ on the concept of guilt ◦ on the presence or absence of God within the workings of the conscience and super-ego ◦ on the process of moral decision-making • whether conscience is linked to, or separate from, reason and the unconscious mind • whether conscience exists at all or is instead an umbrella term covering various factors involved in moral decision-making, such as culture, environment, genetic predisposition and education	
	Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Aquinas and Freud listed above can be found in:</i> • Aquinas, <i>Summa Theologica</i> I–I 79 • Freud, S. <i>The Ego and the Id</i> Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> • Fromm, E. (1947) <i>Man for Himself: An Inquiry into the Psychology of Ethics</i> London: Routledge, IV.2 • Internet Encyclopaedia of Philosophy, <i>Sigmund Freud</i>, http://www.iep.utm.edu/freud/ • Stroh, P. (2011) <i>Conscience: A Very Short Introduction</i>, Oxford University Press, Chapters 1 and 3	

6. Developments in Ethical Thought

How the study of ethics has, over time, influenced and been influenced by developments in religious beliefs and practices, societal norms and normative theories

Sexual Ethics

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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • consideration of the following areas of sexual ethics: <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ◦ premarital and extramarital sex ◦ homosexuality • the influence of developments in religious beliefs and practices on debates about the morality, legality and tolerability of these areas of sexual ethics • application of the following theories to these areas of sexual ethics: <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ◦ natural law ◦ situation ethics ◦ Kantian ethics ◦ utilitarianism | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • traditional religious beliefs and practices (from any religious perspectives) regarding these areas of sexual ethics • how these beliefs and practices have changed over time, including: <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ◦ key teachings influencing these beliefs and practices ◦ the ideas of religious figures and institutions • the impact of secularism on these areas of sexual ethics • how these theories might be used to make moral decisions in these areas of sexual ethics • issues raised in the application of these theories |
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Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to ideas about sexual ethics and changing attitudes towards it, including:

- whether or not religious beliefs and practices concerning sex and relationships have a continuing role in the area of sexual ethics
- whether choices in the area of sexual behaviour should be entirely private and personal, or whether they should be subject to societal norms and legislation
- whether normative theories are useful in what they might say about sexual ethics

Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority

*Learners will be given credit for referring to any **appropriate** scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful*

- Pope Paul VI (1968) *Humanae Vitae*
- Church of England House of Bishops (1991) *Issues in Human Sexuality*, London: Church House Publishing
- Mill, J.S. (1859) *On Liberty*, Chapter 1